Alderscar Furniture: change, risk and the next move

Student workbook | Pearson Edexcel A level Business (9BS0), Theme 3 | Original TBS three-lesson case

Over three lessons you will advise the Managing Director of a small family furniture maker. Lesson 1: judge how fast to introduce a new computer system, using the factors that shape change and some figures from a staff survey. Lesson 2: plan for three risks, work out what each is worth and decide which protections to fund. Lesson 3: use what you know from Theme 3 (objectives, growth, investment appraisal and ratios) to judge two ways to grow and write a recommendation of about 170 words.

Alderscar Furniture Ltd, Eastgill Workshops Ltd, Wexmoor Home Stores and every person, price, percentage and date in this case are fictional. You need a calculator. This is original classroom practice, not an exam paper.

The business

Alderscar Furniture Ltd makes solid oak and ash tables, chairs and cabinets in the Alderscar valley in northern England. The Rudd family has run it since 1952. Elspeth Rudd, the third generation, is Managing Director. It has 42 employees in four departments and annual sales of £4,000,000. All its timber comes from woods within 25 miles.

Department	Staff	Who leads it
Workshop	14	Tamsin Holt, master joiner for 31 years
Finishing and dispatch	12	Joss Garrow, supervisor
Showroom	9	Nia Fenwick, manager
Office and sales	7	Imran Qureshi, Finance Manager, who also looks after the computers (the firm has no IT department)

Mission statement: "Alderscar Furniture exists to make honest furniture from local timber and to keep good jobs in the valley."

Wexmoor Home Stores, a national furniture retailer, buys 35% of the firm's furniture by value (£1,400,000 a year).

SAMPLE

Sample: full pack at thebusiness.school/shop

Free sample

Alderscar Furniture: change, risk and the next move

Contents of the full pack

Lesson 1: How fast should we change?

Lesson 2: Planning for what might go wrong

Lesson 3: The board decides

Student workbook and teacher guide, as PDF and as editable Word files.

The teacher guide has lesson plans, full worked answers and indicative guidance.

This sample is the cover and the first two pages of Lesson 1 of the student workbook. It contains no answers. The pages that follow are exactly as in the full pack.

SAMPLE

Lesson 1: How fast should we change?

Four things shape how a change goes in a business: its organisational culture, the size of the organisation, the time or speed of the change, and how resistance to change is managed.

Starter: four terms (5 minutes)

Write the matching term from this list: organisational culture, size of organisation, speed of change, resistance to change.

Meaning	Term
1. How long a change takes and how quickly it is carried out	
2. The shared habits, beliefs and "way we do things" in a business	
3. Staff reluctance or refusal to accept a change	
4. The number of employees and departments	

Calculate: a survey finds that 12 of 48 staff oppose a change. What percentage is that?

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Task 1: sort the evidence (individual, 8 minutes)

Write which factor each piece of evidence shows: culture, size, speed or resistance. Each factor is used twice.

No.	Evidence	Factor
1	In the staff survey, 9 of the 42 staff said they oppose the change.	
2	Elspeth Rudd speaks to all 42 staff together at the Monday meeting.	
3	Every job since 1952 has been recorded by hand. Tamsin: "Paper never crashes."	
4	Wexmoor Home Stores will stop ordering unless electronic job records are in use by week 17.	
5	Three finishing staff said at a meeting: "Nobody asked us."	
6	New ideas are usually tried in the showroom first, and staff say "we ask the people who do the job".	
7	Only one person, Imran Qureshi, can look after the computers, because the firm is too small for an IT department.	
8	Joss Garrow: "We cannot stop the finishing line for more than a few days."	

b. Choose one factor that makes a fast change harder and one that makes it easier. Explain each in a sentence, using the case.

SAMPLE

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